National Estuary Program Online Reporting Tool (NEPORT) User Manual for NEP Staff

2023

Habitat Reporting

General Habitat Information

What is habitat?

For purposes of NEPORT, habitat is defined as the natural environment of a plant or animal (which includes the total environmental conditions for food, cover, and water within its home range/essential fish habitat). Use NEPORT to report projects that benefit a habitat which meets this definition.

What to report and submit?

On-the-ground habitat protection and restoration project descriptions should only address work completed during the current Federal Fiscal Year. The habitat work reported in NEPORT must be tied to an action in the CCMP. In cases where the habitat work is done via a grant or contract to an NEP partner, please report the acreage only after the habitat work has been completed, not at the time of award issuance.

Habitat protection and restoration projects, or phases of multiple year projects that have been completed can be submitted. Completed means on-the-ground restoration work was done, or the closing process was concluded/easement recorded in the case of land acquisitions and easements.

Non-point source reduction/water quality related projects can be submitted/approved only if there is a documented measurable link to habitat (e.g., nitrogen reductions improve water quality, which increases the seagrass acreage to x amount - that quantifiable acreage can be entered into NEPORT).

What should I not report?

The CWA prohibits the discharge of dredged or fill material into waters of the United States unless a permit issued by the Army Corps of Engineers or approved State under CWA Section 404 authorizes such a discharge.

When there is a proposed discharge, the impact of the discharge must be avoided or minimized to the extent practicable. For unavoidable impacts, compensatory mitigation is required to replace the loss of wetland functions in the watershed. Compensatory mitigation is defined as, “the restoration, creation, enhancement, or in exceptional cases preservation of wetlands and/or other aquatic resources for the purpose of compensating for unavoidable impacts."

Wetlands created or improved as mitigation for the loss or degradation of other wetland resources associated with a permit under the authority of Section 404 of the CWA are not to be counted in your NEPORT submission. These projects could include fills for development, water resource projects (such as dams and levees), or infrastructure development (such as highways and airports). Compensatory mitigation projects should not be submitted in NEPORT.

What are some ineligible habitat types?

Stormwater conveyances, stormwater ponds/catchments, rain gardens, tree farms, and golf courses are not considered habitat for purposes of NEPORT so should not be reported in NEPORT. Although we recognize the value of these types of projects, we do not believe they closely replicate natural system reference structure, processes, condition, and functional services, do not meet our habitat definition, and thus do not fit the intent of this reporting. Although not eligible as habitats themselves, they can be reported as restoration techniques for other habitats (e.g., ponds or wetlands) through the stormwater/runoff controls option.

How are multi-year projects reported?

Long- term habitat projects can be reported at the end of each phase of the project, or at the very end of the project when completed. Enter the start date and report in year completed, to avoid overlap/double counting.

Can I select multiple restoration techniques for a habitat project?

NEPORT will only accept one restoration technique. Allowing multiple techniques would impact the way the charts and graphs are created, as the acreage reported could not be mapped to a single restoration technique.

How do I categorize multiple habitats on my site?

When reporting a project that has various habitat categories, choose the habitat category that represents the greatest acreage. Use the same logic when choosing an activity and restoration technique.

An "other" habitat category has been added to capture habitat types not regularly seen or reported by more than a few NEP, such as canyon, coastal sage scrub, abandoned orchards or vineyards, and pocosin wetlands.

However, many projects have been listed under the "other" category in order to account for multiple habitats found on the site. These listings are enlarging the "other" category, and diluting its value as a repository for relatively rare habitats not found among the usual types.

It is recognized that projects often contain multiple habitats; however, the GPRA habitat performance measure was specifically designed to capture acreage of single habitat types per project rather than percentage of multiple habitats, and that decision dictates the NEPORT database design. At the same time, we also agree with your input on the burdens and difficulty found in measuring and obtaining percentages for multiple habitat types for each project from your partners.

At this time, therefore, we continue to ask that you choose and report on the appropriate dominant/significant habitat type when multiple habitats exist on the site. Please limit your use of the "other" category to those habitats that are more rare or unusual.

What should I use as the project location?

The project should be located within the NEP study area. The latitude/longitude for the project should ideally be located near the center of the project location or parcel of land/segment of habitat being reported.

What should I do if a project is completed between the submission deadline and the close of the reporting period on September 30th?

If you can determine the number of acres of habitat that will be protected or restored by the project by the end of September, and have the other data in hand to fill out the fields in NEPORT, report that project. If this information cannot be obtained prior to the reporting due date in mid-September, submit that project in NEPORT the following year.

Can I submit a project that was previously reported?

We recognize that routine maintenance of habitat can occur for years on a continuous basis. However, to maintain the integrity of NEPORT, do not re-count that same maintenance-related project/acreage more than once. In addition, only report a land acquisition project/parcel acreage once.

With that said, you can submit a project previously reported if a new/different restoration technique is being used from the one identified in previous reporting years. An example of this is a parcel of land purchased and reported in NEPORT for a previous year as land acquisition; in a subsequent year, a different restoration technique (such as streambank stabilization) has been employed to that same area/acres for the newly completed project.

Below are the habitat form fields:

1. **Federal Fiscal Year:** Uneditable field. Will default to the current federal fiscal year.
2. **NEP:** Required field. Select the appropriate NEP from the dropdown list.
3. **EPA Region:** Required field. The region is automatically selected based on the NEP chosen above.
4. **State:** Select the state from the dropdown list. If the NEP spans several states, NEPs may enter the state where the project is located based on the latitude and longitude.
5. **CCMP Action:** Required field. Enter the CCMP action(words/phrases) that the project is addressing, and if more than one action, separate actions using a comma. There is a 500-character limit.
6. **Project Name:** Required field. Enter the project name. There is a 500-character limit.
7. **Habitat Description:** Required field. Briefly describe the habitat general characteristics (sources of impacts, significant features, site uses, etc.). The minimum number of characters that this field requires is 25 and the maximum is 500. If you enter less than 25 or more than 500 characters, including spaces, NEPORT will not let you submit the project.
8. **Habitat Description:** Required Field. Profile a brief description of the habitat. The minimum number of characters for this field is 25 and the maximum is 500. If you enter less than 25 or more than 500 characters, including spaces, NEPORT will not let you submit the project.
9. **Project Description:** Required field. Provide a brief description of what took place: background context such as why the restoration/protection is necessary; general location in the estuary/study area; brief elaboration of the restoration technique used; and the intended project outcomes. The minimum number of characters that this field requires is 75 and the maximum is 750. If you enter less than 75 or more than 750 characters, including spaces, NEPORT will not let you submit the project.
10. **Habitat Type:** Required field. Select one habitat category from the dropdown list. When reporting a project that has multiple habitat categories, select the one that represents the greatest acreage. The definition of each habitat category is provided in Appendix B.
11. **Restoration Technique:** Required field. Select one restoration technique from the dropdown list. If you cannot divide the acres by habitat category and report each acreage separately, choose the habitat category with the largest acreage on the site; report that acreage, along with the associated restoration technique that took place on that portion of the parcel. The definition of each restoration technique is provided in Appendix C.
12. **Previously Reported:** Select yes from the dropdown list if the project acreage has been reported in past years. This is a way to keep track of acreage being double counted due to multiple actions taking place on the same site. For example, a parcel of land could be acquired one year and reported in NEPORT, then restored the following year with the same acreage reported in NEPORT.
13. **Activity:** Required field. Select one activity from the list provided. The definition of each activity is provided in the Appendix D.
14. **Acres:** Acres, linear miles, or linear feet is required. If the project has restored/protected acres, linear miles, or linear feet, enter a number with at least two decimal places. If you enter a number for acres, **do not enter a number for linear miles or linear feet**. If the project did not restore/protect any acres, linear miles, or linear feet, enter "0" in one field only.
15. **Linear Miles:** Acres, linear miles, or linear feet is required. If the project has restored/protected acres, linear miles, or linear feet, enter a number with at least two decimal places. If you enter a number for linear miles, **do not enter a number for acres or linear feet**. If the project did not restore/protect any acres, linear miles, or linear feet, enter "0" in one field only.
16. **Linear Feet:** Acres, linear miles, or linear feet is required. If the project has restored/protected acres, linear miles, or linear feet, enter a number with at least two decimal places. If you enter a number for linear feet, **do not enter a number for acres or linear miles**. If the project did not

restore/protect any acres, linear miles, or linear feet, enter “0” in one field only.

17. **Latitude:** Required field. Enter project’s latitude coordinates in decimal degrees with three decimal points. All U.S. latitude values are positive since the U.S. is north of the equator. If you cannot obtain the project coordinates, enter “00.000.” If an incorrect format is entered, NEPORT will prompt you to enter the coordinates correctly.

L

atitude/Longitude

When entering latitude and longitude values:

Enter in decimal degree format (e.g., 45.34567). Be as precise as possible by providing at least 3 digits after the decimal, but no more than 5.

DO NOT add N or W after the number.

All latitude values in the U.S. are **positive**, since the U.S. is north of the equator.

All longitude values are **negative**, since the U.S. is west of the prime meridian. Entries must begin with a minus sign, e.g., -88.45803. (A minus sign will be added automatically if one isn’t entered.)

An easy-to-use tool is available to convert from degrees/minutes/seconds (e.g., 38□ 47’ 52’’ N, 75□ 05’ 34’’ W) to decimal degrees at the FCC’s Degrees Minutes Seconds to/from Decimal Degrees tool.

18. **Longitude:** Required field. Enter project's longitude coordinates in decimal degrees, with three decimal points. All U.S. longitude values are negative since the U.S. is west of the prime meridian (i.e., values must begin with a minus sign). If you cannot obtain the project coordinates, enter "00.000." See the box above for Latitude/Longitude instructions. If an incorrect format is entered, NEPORT will prompt you to enter the coordinates correctly.
19. **Lead Implementer:** Required field. The project's lead implementer is the primary person, group, or entity responsible for completing the specific habitat protection/restoration activity as indicated in one of the following: 1) CCMP Action Plan, 2) NEP Annual Workplan, or 3) other Program documents such as a restoration plan or list. They may conduct the actual on-the-ground work (e.g., site manipulation), procure the services of a contractor that carries out the work, or provide the key funding for the action. In the case of land acquisition or conservation easements, the lead implementer typically negotiates an option or an agreement to purchase the land or easement, and identifies and secures funding for purchasing the land or easement.
20. **Partners:** Enter the unabbreviated partners' names, if any. If more than one partner, separate them with commas. If no other partners were involved in the project, enter "None". The minimum number of characters required is four. If you enter less than four characters, including spaces, NEPORT will not let you submit the project.
21. **Site Owner:** Required field. Enter the name of only one entity. Indicate whether this is a federal entity, state agency, private landowner, business, or other entity that owns the site. The specific name of the private land owner is not required.
22. **Total Project Cost:** Enter the total project cost, if available (only one field from 21-23 is required).
23. **Data Not Available (Total Project Cost)**: Select this checkbox to indicate the data is not available.
24. **Donated Land at No Cost**: Select this checkbox if the land was donated at no cost.
25. **EPA Section 320 (or section 119) Funds Contributed (cash not in-kind):** Required field; only accepts numbers. If the value of this field is zero, enter "0." *Note:* Section 320 funds do not count as leveraged dollars.
26. **Main Funding Source:** Required field; no abbreviations. The main funding source includes the entity that provides funding for the work being reported and their particular financial assistance program (e.g., NOAA Community Based Restoration Program).
27. **Project Benefits:** Required field. Check one or more project benefits boxes in the list provided.
28. **Photos:** NEPs may add up to three photos – one to show the site before, one during, and one after restoration. Photos to be uploaded must be in one of the following formats: gif, .jpg, or .png. Do not upload Word or PDF documents. It is strongly recommended that you add photos after saving the project as a draft or submitting it for review. Large photo files will take a significant amount of time to upload. The EPA recommends limiting photos to 3 MB or less. You may add captions for the photos, and must provide credits and check the box to affirm that you have permission to use the photo and grant EPA permission to use it.
29. **NEP Author Email:** Required field. Enter the author of the document.
30. **NEP Comments:** This field can be used by NEPs to provide EPA more information about the project. Only NEPs can write information in this field; the region and EPA cannot alter information in this field. There is a 4000-character limit for this field.
31. **Region Comments:** After a project is submitted, the region will use this field to provide guidance on what other information is needed before the project can be approved. Only the region can write information in this field; NEPs cannot alter information in this field.
32. **HQ Comments:** After a project is submitted, EPA will use this field to provide guidance on what other information is needed before the project can be approved. Only EPA can write information in this field; NEPs cannot alter information in this field.

Habitat Data – Land Acquisition View

The habitat data are categorized in this view by restoration technique (i.e., land acquisition). Year, region, NEP name, project name, category name, and restoration technique (i.e., land acquisition) are listed for each project. To view Land Acquisition, click on **Land Acquisition** on the NEPORT homepage under Habitat Data.

Habitat Data – Grand Total Habitat Acres (All Years) View

The habitat data are categorized in this view by region. Total acres are listed for each region for all years. To view Grand Total Habitat Acres (All Years), click on **Grand Total Habitat Acres (All Years)** on the NEPORT homepage under Habitat Data.

Habitat Data – Habitat Photos (All Years) View

The habitat data are categorized in this view by year. Year, NEP name, project name, and photos (e.g., before, during, after) are listed for each project. To view Habitat Photos, click on **Habitat Photos (All Years)** on the NEPORT homepage under Habitat Data.

Habitat Data – Total Acres by Habitat Type, Multi Years

This view is useful for viewing the habitat type, for a given project, by year. Year, NEP name, habitat type and total acres are listed for each project. For this view, click on Total Acres by Habitat Type Multi Year on the NEPORT homepage under Habitat Data.

Total Acres by Restoration Technique

This view is useful for viewing the restoration technique, for a given project, by year. Year, Region, NEP name, habitat type, restoration technique and total acres are listed for each project. For this view, click on Total Acres by Restoration Technique on the NEPORT homepage under Habitat Data.

Total Projects Count by Project Benefits

This view is useful for viewing the project benefits by year. The Year, Project Benefits, and the number of projects with that benefit for the year are listed. For this view, click on Total Projects Count by Project Benefits on the NEPORT homepage under Habitat Data.

Appendix B: Habitat Category Definitions

For NEPORT purposes, habitat is defined as the natural environment of a plant or animal (including the total environmental conditions for food, cover, and water within its home range/essential fish habitat).

There have been some reported projects in the past years that included stormwater conveyances, stormwater ponds/catchments, rain gardens, and golf courses. Although there is a recognized value in these types of projects, it is felt that they do not closely replicate natural system reference structures, processes, conditions, functional services, or the EPA habitat definition. These types do not fit the intent of this reporting and are ineligible as habitat in NEPORT.

Reserve the use of the "Other" habitat category to capture habitat types not regularly seen or reported by more than a few NEPs, such as, canyon, coastal sage scrub, abandoned orchards or vineyards, and pocosin wetlands.

The "Other" habitat category should not be used to indicate *multiple types* of habitat categories. While we recognize that projects often do contain multiple habitats, the GPRA habitat performance measure was designed specifically to capture acreage of single habitat types per project rather than percentages of multiple habitats. This decision dictates the NEPORT database design. Therefore, we continue to ask that you choose and report on the appropriate dominant/significant habitat type when multiple habitats exist on the site. The habitat category definitions are listed below.

Agriculture/Ranch Land: Land used for cultivating soil, producing crops, and raising livestock; farming and ranching.

Beach: The area of land at the ocean shore, marked by an accumulation of sand, stone, and other sediment that has been deposited by the water, and is exposed to and shaped by waves and wind; does not usually support permanent vegetation.

Coral Reef: A three-dimensional structure consisting primarily of a calcium carbonate framework that is composed of skeletons of reef-building corals and calcareous red algae, inhabiting areas within the ocean's continental shelf and slope. Coral colonies help build the reef's structure by continually secreting a hard calcium carbonate skeleton that builds over time. This habitat can be found in depths ranging from shallow water during low tide to approximately 150 feet.

Dune: A hill or ridge of sand that has accumulated by wind-driven transport, representing a gradient from sea to land; serves as a habitat for various fauna and may support permanent vegetation.

Estuarine Shoreline: A sediment bank (e.g., bluff), or that area located immediately adjacent to the estuary/bay proper.

Estuarine Water Column: The volume of water extending from the surface down to, but not including, the substrate. Water column refers to the open water of an estuary (but not to that of a river, stream, or pond for purposes of reporting in NEPORT).

Field/Meadow: A grassy area; a treeless clearing within a forest or on a mountainside, or an area on a farm on which alfalfa (for hay) is grown**.**

Forested Wetland: Areas dominated by woody vegetation 6 meters (20 feet) or taller which remain saturated

throughout the year and may flood seasonally; also known as “swamps.” **Appendix B**

Forest/Woodland: An area of land covered by trees and understory vegetation, sometimes mixed with pasture; forests are described in terms of crown cover, such as closed forest, open forest, woodland and open woodland, and in terms of height of the tallest stratum, such as tall (over 30 meters), medium (10-30 meters) and low trees (under 10 meters).

Freshwater Marsh: Low-salinity (less than .5 ppt) wetlands characterized by erect, rooted, herbaceous plants which extend above the water’s surface, and are present for most of the growing season in most years. Water levels can range tidally or seasonally from at the soil surface to a shallow depth.

Grassland: Open, treeless areas that are not managed as farmland and are generally dominated by native grasses. Wetlands are not grassland.

Hard Bottom: Shallow and deep-water habitats with substrates consisting of bedrock, rocks, boulders, gravel, or pebbles. The solid floor typically provides an attachment surface for sessile organisms as well as a rough three-dimensional surface that encourages water mixing and nutrient cycling. For the purposes of the Inventory, hard bottom refers to such habitat found in an estuary; restoration of stream or pond bottom habitats should be reported in the In-Steam or Pond category.

In-Stream: The area, including the water column and substrate, located within a stream or river, excluding the streambank.

Island: An island is defined as a piece of land which is separated from the mainland by a body of water open to the ocean, and which has a non-marsh dry interface (such as sand or rock) with the ocean. This includes both barrier and rocky islands.

Lake/Pond: A naturally confined body of freshwater located inland (including the water and substrate of the lake or pond, not including vegetation bordering the lake or pond).

Mangrove: Swamp communities that develop along sheltered tropical and subtropical shores where sediments accumulate in inundated brackish and saltwater areas; dominated by mangrove species -- dense halophytic shrubs and trees characterized by aerial roots.

Other: Select this category if the project’s habitat is not included in the Habitat Category list. If multiple types of habitat are present, select the predominant type rather than selecting ‘Other’.
Living shorelines may be reported in this category.

Riparian: Riparian areas are plant communities contiguous to and affected by surface and subsurface hydrologic features, such as rivers, streams, lakes, or drainage ways. Riparian areas have one or both of the following characteristics: 1) distinctively different vegetative species than adjacent areas, and 2) species similar to adjacent areas but exhibiting more vigorous or robust growth forms. Riparian areas are usually transitional between wetland and upland.
Riparian areas help to reduce flood peaks and they also enhance water quality, soil stability, and groundwater replenishment.

Rocky Shoreline: Wave-exposed coasts with a substrate of boulders, rock, or cobble. Found along the ocean coast and the shores of the Great Lakes.

Submerged Aquatic Vegetation (SAV): Vascular plants that grow below the surface of the water on soft sediments in sheltered shallow waters of estuaries, bays, lagoons, and lakes. These plants are usually completely inundated throughout the growing season. Some SAV habitats may contain a mix of open water and rooted, floating-leaved, and short-emergent vegetation.

Shell Bottom: Shallow and deep-water habitats with substrates consisting of mollusk shells such as oyster reefs.

Shrub Swamp (non-mangrove): Wetlands dominated by woody vegetation less than 6 m (20 feet) tall; vegetation includes true shrubs, young trees (saplings), and trees or shrubs that are small or stunted because of environmental conditions. Shrub swamps remain saturated throughout the year and may flood seasonally.

Soft Bottom/Mud: Intertidal mudflats or subtidal substrate containing organic material and particles smaller in size than sand. These areas of loose, unconsolidated substrate generally lack rooted vegetation, but may provide appropriate habitat for shellfish beds.

Soft Bottom/Sand: Intertidal sandflats or sandy subtidal areas; composed of loose, unconsolidated substrate characterized by fine to coarse-grained sediment, and normally lacking rooted vegetation.

Salt Marsh: Sheltered waters along the coast which are affected by both tides and freshwater run-off.

Appendix C: Restoration Techniques

The menu of restoration techniques is listed below. Although not eligible as habitats themselves, rain gardens or other stormwater-related activities for habitats may be captured as restoration techniques for other habitats (e.g., ponds or wetlands) through the Stormwater/Runoff Controls option on the Restoration Techniques drop down menu.

- Beach Nourishment
- Berm/Dike Modification (including replacement)
- Berm/Dike Removal
- Bird Habitat Enhancement
- Bridge Replacement
- Bulkhead Removal
- Contaminant Removal/Remediation
- Culvert Modification (including installation and replacement)
- Culvert Removal
- Dam Modification/Removal
- Daylighting
- Debris Removal
- Ditch Removal, Filling, or Plugging
- Easements
- Erosion Control
- Fencing/Netting
- Fill Removal
- Fish Ladder/Fishway
- Fish Barrier Removal
- Invasives Control/Removal - Fauna
- Invasives Control/Removal - Vegetation
- Land Acquisition
- Large Woody Debris/Structure Placement
- Other
- Oyster Gardening
- Placement of Dredged Material
- Planting
- Prescribed Burn
- Rain Garden Creation
- Reef Construction - Artificial Materials
- Reef Construction - Natural Materials
- Sand Dune Restoration
- Shellfish Seeding
- Shoreline Stabilization/Enhancement
- Stormwater/Runoff Controls
- Stream Channel Rehabilitation
- Stream Flow Modification (including stream pool construction)
- Stream Bank Stabilization
- Substrate Modification
- Terracing
- Tide Gate Installation
- Tide Gate Modification (including replacement)

- Tide Gate Removal
- Vegetation Buffer
- Weir Construction
- Weir Removal

Appendix C